

William James on the Unity of Science

Question: Can you find a quote from William James that talks about sciences and whether they converge on a single science, or whether they deal with separate realities?

What Matters? (Flach & Voorhorst) cites William James directly on this point:

"Most thinkers have a faith that at bottom there is but one Science of all things, and that until all is known, no one thing can be completely known." — William James, *Psychology* (Henry Holt and Company), p. 1

Follow-up: Do you have access to the more complete quotation in the original source?

Yes. The citation is accurate but trimmed. It comes from the opening of Chapter I ("Introductory") of James's *Psychology: Briefer Course* (1892, Henry Holt & Co.) — an abridgment of his larger *Principles of Psychology*. The "1909" date in the *What Matters?* citation is a later Henry Holt reprint of this same text; the passage and page 1 match exactly.

The fuller passage:

"Psychology is to be treated as a natural science in this book. This requires a word of commentary. Most thinkers have a faith that at bottom there is but one Science of all things, and that until all is known, no one thing can be completely known. Such a science, if realized, would be Philosophy. Meanwhile it is far from being realized; and instead of it, we have a lot of beginnings of knowledge made in different places, and kept separate from each other merely for practical convenience' sake, until with later growth they may run into one body of Truth. These provisional beginnings of learning we call 'the Sciences' in the plural. In order not to be unwieldy, every such science has to stick to its own arbitrarily-selected problems, and to ignore all others."

James then runs through examples of exactly this arbitrary narrowing — physics assumes matter and force without justifying them, chemistry uncritically takes physics's data, physiology takes chemistry's — and lands the point on psychology itself:

"Psychology as a natural science deals with things in the same partial and provisional way... The full truth about states of mind cannot be known until both Theory of Knowledge and Rational Psychology have said their say. Meanwhile an immense amount of provisional truth about them can be got together, which will work in with the larger truth and be interpreted by it when the proper time arrives."

What This Adds

The fuller context sharpens what *What Matters?* was doing with the one-liner. James isn't just musing that all sciences *might* converge — he is explaining, as a methodological justification right at the start of a psychology textbook, why he is deliberately treating psychology as one of the provisional, arbitrarily-bounded "Sciences" (plural) rather than waiting for the unified "Philosophy" that would eventually need it. The separateness of the sciences is candidly a practical, temporary expedient, not a claim about separate underlying realities.

Source

William James, *Psychology: Briefer Course* (New York: Henry Holt and Company, 1892), Chapter I. Public domain
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